

Practice Paper 5 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — “The way another man might count beads”

1 mark for identifying that the narrator was **nervous** / **anxious** / **seeking comfort**; **1 mark** for the link to **repetition for reassurance** (like a prayer or meditation).

Sample answer: The comparison suggests that the narrator was **deeply anxious** and was using the repeated sentences as a **source of comfort**, much like a person mechanically repeats a prayer to steady themselves in a frightening situation.

Q2. [2] — Why the laughter, not the heat, frightened him

1 mark — The laughter was a sign that the other workers **belonged** / were **at ease** in the factory.

1 mark — It made the narrator suddenly aware that he was an **outsider** — the contrast between their familiarity and his strangeness was what frightened him.

Q3. [1] — Overwhelming environment

1 mark for any **one** of:

- “Two hundred sewing machines ran together... at a pace I could not... follow with my eyes.”
- “Fluorescent tubes hummed overhead.”
- “A radio... was playing a song I did not recognise, in a language I did not understand.”
- The noise “hit” him before the heat did.

Q4. [2] — The supervisor’s smile

1 mark — The supervisor was **professionally courteous**, not warm or friendly.

1 mark — But he was also **not cold or hostile** — he left the door open to a future relationship without committing to one. (Accept: politely neutral / reservedly kind.)

Q5. [2] — “It cost him nothing, and it kept me upright”

1 mark — **Contrast** between the **small effort** required of the supervisor (the smile cost him nothing).

1 mark — and the **enormous effect** it had on the narrator (it gave him the strength to keep going, both physically and emotionally — “kept me upright”). The writer is showing how **tiny kindnesses** can have **large consequences**.

Q6. [2] — “Not difficult; it was simply relentless”

1 mark — The task itself was **easy to learn** / not technically demanding.

1 mark — But it was **unending and repetitive**, with **no pause or variation** — the difficulty came from the **sheer endurance** required, not from any skill.

Q7. [2] — “Two fingers” and “an inch”

1 mark — The tiny details emphasise the **quiet, almost secret** nature of the woman’s gesture — she did not draw attention to it.

1 mark — They show that kindness in this place is offered **modestly, without ceremony or eye contact**, perhaps because openly helping a newcomer might be noticed or disapproved of. (Also accept: it shows the woman’s **exhaustion** — she could only spare the smallest movement.)

Q8. [1] — Why he held back his tears

1 mark — Because “the men around [him] would have seen” — he did not want to **show weakness** / **lose his dignity** in front of the other workers.

Q9. [3] — Quietness of the supervisor’s kindness (language question)

1 mark for identifying the **understated** / **silent** nature of the kindness; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “took the piece from my hands, refolded it without a word” — the verb **without a word** emphasises that no rebuke was spoken.
- “He did not scold me. He did not even shake his head.” — the **parallel negatives** underline the supervisor’s restraint.
- “He simply showed me, again, what to do, and walked on.” — the adverb **simply** and the casual **walked on** make the act seem almost incidental.
- “A small mercy, performed in passing” — the phrase **in passing** shows the kindness was done quietly, without ceremony.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q10. [1] — Repetition of “that”

1 mark — The repetition **fixes the memory in time and place** — “that biscuit, that wall, that first evening” — making the moment feel **vivid, specific, and unforgettable** to the narrator. (Also accept: it conveys **reverence** / a sense that the moment was **sacred**.)

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **quietly proud, reflective, resolved, accepting, dignified.** (Reject: **triumphant, bitter, sad** — these miss the calm, settled quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [1] — Writer's attitude to the weaver

1 mark — **Sympathetic / compassionate / respectful / understanding.** The writer presents the weaver without judgement, acknowledging that his sons' departure is reasonable and that the weaver bears no bitterness. (Reject: **pitying**, which implies condescension.)

Q13. [2] — Slow, tired smile and changing the subject

1 mark — He is **pessimistic / resigned** about the craft's survival; he believes it will probably **not outlive him**.

1 mark — But he does not want to **say so openly**, perhaps because it is too painful, or because complaining would serve no purpose — so he deflects the question instead.

Q14. [2] — Why crafts are losing out

1 mark each for any two of:

- Industrial production is **faster** (a power loom produces in a day what a hand-weaver produces in a fortnight).
- Industrial production is **cheaper** (a plastic basket costs a fifth of a bamboo one).
- Industrial production is **more consistent** in quality / output.
- Younger artisans see craft as a **poorly paid trap** and prefer to pursue **education** and other careers instead.

Q15. [2] — “On the face of it”

1 mark — The phrase means **at first glance / on the surface**.

1 mark — The writer uses it to suggest that the economic argument **appears** obvious and decisive, but he is **hinting** that the full picture is **more complicated** — there is more to the story than economics alone. (This prepares the reader for the counter-arguments in later paragraphs.)

Q16. [2] — Inverted commas around “souvenir”

1 mark — The inverted commas show that the word is being used **ironically / sceptically** — these items are called souvenirs but are not authentic crafts.

1 mark — The writer is **distancing** himself from the term and **signalling disapproval**: the items are cheap imitations made by people who no longer hold the genuine skills, despite being marketed as traditional.

Q17. [2] — “Sometimes uneasy” vs “quietly proud”

1 mark — **Uneasy**: the older artisans are **unsettled** by the changes their children have brought — new prices, new marketing, new methods of selling — which feel strange compared with how the craft has always been practised.

1 mark — **Proud**: yet they also recognise that their children have **secured the craft's survival** and **raised its value**, and they admire this achievement, even if they do not say so openly.

Q18. [2] — “The object remains; the story does not”

1 mark — A machine can **reproduce the appearance** of a hand-made item perfectly.

1 mark — But it cannot reproduce the **history, meaning, and human knowledge** — the **generations of practice, the specific village, the particular family** — that gave the original object its cultural value. The physical thing survives, but its **significance** is lost.

Reject answers that lift “story” without explaining it.

Q19. [1] — Tone of “authenticity cannot be bottled”

1 mark — Any **one** of: **sceptical, dismissive, wryly critical, cautionary**. (Reject: **angry, bitter**.)

Q20. [2] — Two short sentences instead of one

1 mark — The **short, blunt sentences** give the statement **force and finality** — they make the writer’s point sound **decisive and undeniable**.

1 mark — The separation also **emphasises the contrast** between what slowness is **not** (a flaw) and what it **is** (the product itself) — splitting them makes the second sentence land like a **correction** of a common assumption.

Q21. [2] — Effect of ending with a question

1 mark — The **rhetorical question** directly **challenges the reader** and invites personal reflection rather than passive agreement.

1 mark — It also **broadens the issue** beyond Asia and beyond craft, turning it into a **universal question** about modern life — what we lose when everything is made anonymously and in haste — which gives the article a **thought-provoking, resonant close**.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Why traditional crafts in Asia are declining (Paragraph 2):

1. **Industrial production is much faster** than hand-making (a power loom matches a fortnight’s hand-weaving in a day).
2. Industrial production is **significantly cheaper** (e.g. plastic baskets cost a fifth of bamboo ones).
3. Industrial production is **more consistent** in quality and supply.
4. **Younger artisans regard the trade as poorly paid** and prefer education and other careers.

What is being done to save them (Paragraphs 3–4):

5. **Governments have launched revival schemes** (e.g. India’s One District One Product, Vietnam’s craft-village tourism, Indonesia’s geographical-indication batik labels).
6. These schemes provide **subsidies, training, and certificates of authenticity** that allow genuine items to **command higher prices**.
7. A **new generation of educated young artisans** has returned to take over family workshops, **rebranding** them and **selling internationally** through online platforms and fashion collaborations.

8. They have **raised prices** to reflect real labour (e.g. a sari that fetched 1,500 rupees in 2010 now fetches six times that amount).

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Traditional crafts in Asia are declining because mechanised production is faster, cheaper, and more uniform than hand-making, while younger workers see the trade as badly paid and choose education instead. To counter this, governments have introduced subsidies, training, and authenticity labels that let genuine items charge a premium. A new generation of educated artisans has also returned home, rebranding family workshops, selling overseas through online platforms, partnering with foreign designers, and raising prices to reflect real labour.

Length count: 78 words from “Traditional” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —